

# Maamarei Mordechai

הסבר לפי ממש פשוט

Parshas Vaeschanan 5786

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Moshe teaches an amazing lesson by how he recounts the Ten Utterances.

**שָׁמֹר אֶת-יְוֹם הַשַּׁבָּת לְקֹדֶשׁ כַּאֲשֶׁר צִוְּךָ ה' אֱלֹהֶיךָ:**

“Guard the Day of Shabbos, for its holiness; just as Hashem, your Lord, commanded you.” (Devarim 5:12).

Moshe changed the wording of the Aseres Hadibros from Shmos 20. Why? If the nation all heard it from Hashem’s mouth and it is paramount to our faith—the public revelation—why did he believe he was able to change it?

Moshe repeats the Aseres HaDibros nearly forty years after they were first proclaimed at Har Sinai (which he calls Chorev). (Ibid 5:2). If the Torah (and Moshe) is so careful with every word, why doesn't Moshe simply quote them? Instead, he modifies numerous phrases. Some are subtle, while others alter the emphasis of the mitzvos themselves.

Moshe is speaking to an entirely different audience—the children of the geula, not the generation that stood beneath the mountain. They were mere children during the Revelation at Har Sinai. Now they are all grown up, and their parents are gone. They are not leaving Eretz Mitzrayim but preparing to build a nation in Eretz Yisrael. The changes reveal precisely what Moshe wants this new generation to understand.

Take "Remember" or "Observe" for example. The most famous difference is the opening of the mitzvah of Shabbos. Hashem said, זָכוֹר אֶת-יְוֹם הַשַּׁבָּת - “Recall the day of Shabbos.” (Shmos 20:8). Moshe said, שָׁמֹר אֶת-יְוֹם הַשַּׁבָּת - “Guard the day...” (While Chazal teach that both were said simultaneously, expressing two inseparable dimensions of Shabbos, we explained why Moshe used the different wording, in Maamarei Mordechai Parshas Vaeschanan 5784). As we explained earlier, the generation was new to Shabbos so they could only merely recall it. Now, after forty years of practice, they can observe and guard it. This is also important for a nation that is about to become farmers, merchants, judges, craftsmen, and soldiers during the week and will face a challenge the wilderness generation never did, actually resting from parnassah on Shabbos. The greatest threat to Shabbos in the Land would not be a lack of recalling it, but allowing everyday labor to consume it. That is why Moshe emphasized that they must guard it.

Moshe also gave a different reason for keeping Shabbos. In Shmos, Hashem said the reason was because He was the Creator and He rested on the seventh day. (Ibid 20:11). Here, it is because Hashem redeemed the nation from bondage. And not only that, the nation “were indentured servants and Hashem took them out with a mighty hand and outstretched arm.” (Devarim 5:15). Both are important and have their time. Upon leaving bondage, Bnei Yisroel knew what Hashem did for them. They did not know *why* Hashem did it for them. Hashem explained it was because He is Creator, he owns everything and everyone—they are all His creations. Therefore, he built into the world a Shabbos. It was

for Bnei Yisroel—the nation he acquired for Himself, to keep it. For the generation entering Eretz Yisroel, they have to understand that they owe everything to Hashem. They may not see it in their daily lives but Hashem freed them with signs and wonders. Additionally, they are different than all other peoples. The people of the world are free to come and learn about Hashem and worship Hashem. However, Shabbos was only given to Bnei Yisroel—who Hashem took out of bondage—not the entire world—that He created.

Another lesson is in how and why to honor one's parents. Here, it is because "Hashem, your Lord, commanded you to, so that your days shall be long and your days shall be good upon the ground, that Hashem, your Lord, is giving to you." (Ibid 5:15). Hashem had said, so that you days shall be long upon the ground that Hashem, your lord, is giving to you." (Shmos 20:12). Moshe added that life shall be good and because Hashem commanded them. Now, after forty years of learning Torah, they understand what it means to do something because Hashem commanded it. True, Hashem wants them to live long and prosper. However, the lesson here is that it is accomplished or earned by following the Torah. Do not, not for long life, but to fulfill the commandments; and Hashem gave them to you so that you can earn long life. Also, the Torah in both places uses the word "adama" for ground. Not eretz for Land. This is because the command is not reliant on being in Eretz Yisroel. It is so that a man—who will return to the ground—can have a long live above it, wherever he is.

Another practical lesson is the order of coveting. In the last utterance, Hashem said, "You shall not covet your neighbor's house, you shall not covet your neighbor's wife." (Ibid 20:14). Here Moshe says, "You shall not *covet* your neighbor's wife. You shall not *desire* your neighbor's house." (Devarim 5:18). Moshe reformatted the order, the word of covet to desire when it came to the house, and also added in "field."

Moshe taught a profound lesson. Hashem stated the order of importance to mankind. Start with a home, then you can take a wife, then a servant, maidservant, and beasts of burden. Moshe knew the desires of mankind. He just warned against murder, adultery, kidnapping, and false witness in criminal matters. (Ibid 5:17). Such action comes from coveting and desire. Even before a person sees his neighbor's house, or any of his possessions, he covets the happiness and bonds that his neighbor has. He goes after his base desires to covet his neighbor's wife. He desires his neighbor's house, field (added because they are about to be land owners), servants and animals. He wants the actual wife. He does not want the house; he just wants one similar to it.

Moshe had no desire to polish the Aseres HaDibros or to change them in any manner. However, knowing his audience, and knowing where they are going—without him—he left them with important messages. Certainly, these messages are already hidden inside of the Torah. Moshe brought them to light and made them explicit so they would not be missed. His resolute commitment to only convey the authentic Word of Hashem compelled him to alter the wording in a fashion that teaches what Bnei Yisroel were to take from the Aseres HaDibros. Its true test comes after the Revelation has ended—when fields must be planted, businesses must be run, families must be raised, and a nation must live every ordinary day as the people of Hashem.